

Understanding Blood Pressure

What systolic and diastolic values represent.

Systolic pressure

- The upper number: pressure in the arteries when the heart contracts.

Diastolic pressure

- The lower number: pressure in the arteries while the heart relaxes between beats.

Accurate measurement

- Rest quietly, sit with back supported and feet flat, and keep the arm supported at heart level.
- Use the correct cuff size and avoid talking during the reading.
- Diagnosis usually depends on repeated accurate measurements, not one isolated result.

Why it matters

- Long-term high blood pressure increases the risk of stroke, heart disease, kidney disease and eye damage.
- Very high readings with severe symptoms require urgent medical assessment.

Urgent warning

Blood-pressure interpretation depends on age, setting and clinical guidelines. Discuss persistent abnormal readings with a clinician.